



anything else missing or needs further refinement and reinforcement and improve the company and site and application market and launch and contract and user ready having it be complete

Yes. You have covered most of the product vision; what remains is a **completion and launch-control system** that verifies Semester is not only ambitious, but truly safe, sellable, supportable, and usable for real people.

The largest remaining gaps are likely in verification, operations, contracts, customer delivery, migration readiness, real-user validation, and honest market positioning—not in idea generation.

The complete-company checklist

Semester is complete enough to launch when all seven areas are operational:

1. Product works
2. Trust is verifiable
3. Company is legally and financially ready
4. Customers can buy and implement it
5. Users can onboard and get help
6. The platform can be operated and recovered
7. Marketing claims match reality

Product readiness

Core user journeys

Do not launch based on individual screens. Launch only after the major user journeys work end to end.

User	Must complete this journey
Student	Create account → set profile → build plan → see next action → save work → get help
Student planning	Select courses → compare options → resolve conflict → save primary plan and backups → prepare advisor agenda
Student learning	Open course → add/select materials → generate study asset → complete practice → view source → save progress
Student support	Search for help → see verified resource → prepare question → create follow-up action → receive response

User	Must complete this journey
Student career	Save project → confirm skills → create portfolio evidence → prepare application or mentor action
Faculty	Create or manage course context → publish materials/policy → approve source pack → review student-facing experience
Advisor	Receive student-approved agenda → review shared plan → complete follow-up workflow without accessing private data
Staff	Publish a verified resource or action → see content owner status → update or retire content
Institution admin	Configure tenant → roles → content → integrations → features → audit and support workflow
Support team	Receive student-created support grant → diagnose issue → respond → close → audit access
Privacy user	Export personal data → revoke sharing → disconnect account → request deletion
Finance customer	Upgrade or cancel membership → view invoice → manage payment method → retain data export rights

Every journey needs:

Authenticated and unauthorized states
 Empty state
 Loading state
 Error state
 Stale-data state
 Offline or degraded behavior where relevant
 Mobile state
 Keyboard state
 Screen-reader state
 Audit event where sensitive
 Support path

Launch acceptance rule

A feature is **not launch-complete** because it looks built.

It is launch-complete only when it has:

Persistent data
 Authorization
 Source and freshness labels
 Validation
 Accessibility coverage
 Error handling
 Analytics
 Support ownership
 Tests
 Rollback or feature-flag control

Company and legal readiness

Company foundation

Confirm that these basics are complete before public commercial launch:

- Registered business entity and correct ownership documentation.
- Employer Identification Number, business banking, accounting system, and tax process.
- Domain ownership under the business—not only a personal account.
- Professional company email accounts.
- Intellectual-property assignment agreements for employees, contractors, advisors, and agencies.
- Confidentiality agreements where appropriate.
- Contractor agreements with clear ownership of work product.
- Trademark search and legal advice before relying on the name, logo, or visual identity.
- Cyber, technology errors-and-omissions, and general-liability insurance when commercially appropriate.
- Founder agreement, equity records, option plan, and cap-table process where relevant.
- Board/advisor agreements and conflict-of-interest policy.
- Financial controls, approval limits, expenses, and recordkeeping.

Public legal documents

Before taking real user data or payment, publish and maintain:

Privacy Policy
Terms of Service
Acceptable Use Policy
Community Guidelines
Copyright / DMCA process where applicable
AI Policy
Cookie / analytics policy where applicable
Accessibility Statement
Security contact and responsible disclosure policy
Subprocessor Register
Data Retention and Deletion Policy
Support Policy
Incident Response Summary
Advertising and Sponsorship Policy

For institutions, prepare:

Data Processing Addendum
FERPA / student-data privacy summary
Pilot Statement of Work
Master Subscription Agreement

Service Level Agreement
Implementation Statement of Work
Acceptable Use addendum
AI and data-use addendum
Security addendum
Accessibility documentation / VPAT
Business continuity summary

A qualified attorney should review all contracts, privacy representations, payment terms, and institutional agreements. Semester should never promise legal compliance that has not been verified for the relevant deployment and jurisdiction.

Trust and procurement readiness

HECVAT and vendor review

Higher education institutions commonly use HECVAT to evaluate vendor risk. EDUCAUSE describes HECVAT as a questionnaire covering cybersecurity, privacy, IT accessibility, and compliance standards, and says the current version is HECVAT 4.1.0. ^[1] ^[2]

Prepare a **procurement Trust Room** with:

Artifact	Needed for
Executive product overview	Initial institutional discussion
Architecture diagram	IT and security review
Data-flow diagram	Privacy and security review
Data inventory	Privacy, FERPA, and implementation
Security overview	HECVAT and CISO review
HECVAT Lite and Full response	Vendor risk assessment
Privacy and FERPA summary	Legal and privacy review
DPA	Contract review
AI data-use and governance policy	AI review and procurement
Accessibility statement and VPAT	Accessibility office review
Subprocessor register	Privacy and legal review
Incident-response summary	Security review
Business-continuity summary	Enterprise risk review
Support SLA	Procurement and operations review
Integration guide	IT review
Implementation plan	Executive sponsor and project team
Pilot SOW	Commercial and implementation approval

Artifact	Needed for
Insurance certificates	Procurement if requested

FERPA operating posture

If Semester receives institutional education records, do not treat the relationship as an ordinary consumer-app integration. Under FERPA, institutions generally must control access to education-record information and determine whether a third-party provider qualifies to perform an institutional service under the institution’s direct control and for a legitimate educational interest. [^1863]

Operationally, require:

```
Written institutional agreement
Approved purpose limitation
Minimum necessary data
Direct institutional control
No unauthorized redisclosure
Role and object-level authorization
Audit logging
Retention/deletion agreement
Incident-response obligations
Subprocessor disclosure
Institution-controlled configuration
```

User and customer readiness

Student onboarding

A new student should experience value in under five minutes.

1. Create account or use SSO
2. Select the immediate goal
3. Provide minimum context
4. Receive a useful Path, Plan, Study, Support, or Career result
5. Understand why the result appeared
6. Save or act on one next step
7. Receive a light invitation—not a demand—to connect more data

The success metric is not “completed all onboarding steps.” It is:

“I understand what I need to do next.”

Help and support

Build support before public launch:

- In-app help button on every important screen.
- Searchable help center.
- Student feedback and bug-report form.
- Support-ticket workflow.
- Clear response targets.
- Escalation path for privacy, accessibility, account access, security, billing, and urgent resource navigation.
- Status page.
- Known-issues page.
- Product changelog.
- Support-access grants so staff do not automatically see student data.
- Internal runbooks for top problems.
- Accessibility issue-report process.
- AI output reporting workflow.
- Community moderation and safety reporting where social functions are enabled.

Customer success

For every pilot or institutional customer, create a formal success plan:

Institution goal
Pilot cohort
Use case
Executive sponsor
Technical owner
Student-success owner
Privacy/security owner
Content owner
Implementation milestones
Data scope
Success metrics
Support model
Risk log
Expansion decision date

Market and launch readiness

Market truthfulness

Use a **claim register** before publishing marketing language.

Claim	Evidence required
“Secure”	Security controls, monitoring, incident process, evidence
“Accessible”	WCAG testing, VPAT, known limitations, issue process
“AI-powered”	Accurate description of AI functions, providers, controls, limitations
“Integrated”	Real supported integration with documented scope and status
“Replaces”	Native authoritative workflow, migration, support, continuity, institutional agreement
“Improves student success”	Responsible evidence and methodology
“Trusted by”	Written permission and verified customer relationship
“Enterprise-ready”	Contract, security, support, implementation, recovery, and governance capability
“Compliant”	Defined legal or standards scope and external/legal validation

This is especially important because Semester’s vision is intentionally broad. Strong, precise claims are more credible than claims that outrun the current deployment.

Launch assets

The company site should have these pages before outreach:

Homepage
Product overview
How it works
For students
For institutions
For advisors and faculty
For campus services
Pricing
Pilot program
Trust Center
Security
Privacy
Accessibility
AI policy
Integrations
Resources
Help center
Status page
About
Careers
Contact
Changelog

The product should have these conversion points:

```
Start free
Join the pilot
Request a demo
Explore for institutions
Download security overview
Use a free planning tool
Join student advisory council
Become a campus ambassador
Contact partnerships
Contact support
```

Marketing operating system

Build marketing around repeatable content pillars:

- Student clarity and planning.
- Registration and academic navigation.
- Study and learning.
- Campus services and belonging.
- Career and portfolio.
- Transfer and first-year experience.
- Accessibility and inclusive design.
- Responsible AI.
- Institutional fragmentation and connected workflows.
- Product building and reliability.
- Student, advisor, and institution stories with permission.
- Free tools and templates.

Every post should lead to a useful next step:

```
Social post
→ free tool or guide
→ account or newsletter
→ first useful action
→ product activation
→ referral, ambassador, campus pilot, or institution lead
```

Operations and reliability readiness

Production operations

Before describing Semester as reliable, confirm:

```
Production and staging environments separated
Secrets manager in use
Backup schedule configured
Restore drill completed
Monitoring and alerting active
Runtime error tracking active
Database performance monitoring active
Integration-health monitoring active
Feature flags and kill switches active
Release checklist used
Rollback tested
Status page ready
Incident runbook ready
On-call responsibility assigned
Security event logging active
Access reviews scheduled
Dependency and secret scans in CI
```

Service-level objectives

Set internal targets for:

- Sign-in success and latency.
- Page performance.
- Plan save durability.
- Action Center availability.
- Search response time.
- Integration freshness.
- Notification delivery.
- Data export and deletion completion.
- Support response.
- Incident detection and resolution.

Do not publish an SLA until Semester can consistently meet it.

Financial and commercial readiness

Revenue operations

Before taking institutional or consumer payments, define:

- Pricing authority and discount approval.
- Subscription billing provider.

- Invoice and receipt workflow.
- Tax treatment.
- Refund policy.
- Cancellation workflow.
- Failed-payment process.
- Revenue-recognition process.
- Contract repository.
- CRM.
- Sales pipeline stages.
- Proposal and quote templates.
- Renewal process.
- Expansion process.
- Customer health score.
- CAC and payback model.
- AI cost allocation.
- Implementation-cost tracking.
- Gross-margin reporting.

Contract boundaries

Every contract should clearly state:

Scope
Authorized use
Data roles and permitted processing
Security obligations
Accessibility commitments
AI use and provider disclosures
Subprocessors
Support level
Availability expectations
Implementation responsibilities
Integration responsibilities
Pricing and renewal
Confidentiality
Intellectual property
Data ownership
Export and deletion
Incident notification
Termination assistance
Liability and insurance
Governing law

Do not create generic promises that you cannot operationally meet.

The final launch gate

Use this as the company-wide go/no-go checklist.

Product

- ☐ Core student journeys work end to end
- ☐ Core staff and admin workflows work end to end
- ☐ Real auth and persistent data are live
- ☐ Mobile, keyboard, screen reader, error, and loading states are complete
- ☐ Source labels and data freshness are visible
- ☐ Support and feedback paths exist
- ☐ Critical flows have tests and monitoring
- ☐ No demo data is presented as verified production data

Trust

- ☐ Privacy and terms published
- ☐ Security controls reviewed
- ☐ RLS and authorization review complete
- ☐ SECURITY DEFINER function review complete
- ☐ Data inventory and retention schedule complete
- ☐ Export/deletion works
- ☐ AI policy and controls are live
- ☐ Accessibility statement and testing are complete
- ☐ Incident and restore drills performed
- ☐ Subprocessor register published

Company

- ☐ Entity, domain, banking, accounting, contracts, IP, and insurance ready
- ☐ Support, billing, refund, and cancellation processes ready
- ☐ Company email, contact, careers, security, privacy, and accessibility channels are ready
- ☐ Sales materials, pricing, SOW, DPA, MSA, and SLA ready
- ☐ Trust Room and RFP response library ready

Launch and market

- ☐ Website explains current product and future vision honestly
- ☐ Pricing and CTA paths work
- ☐ Product analytics measure meaningful actions
- ☐ Student advisory and pilot recruitment plan is active
- ☐ Customer-success and implementation plan is ready
- ☐ Initial launch cohort is defined
- ☐ Feedback loop, bug triage, and release process are active
- ☐ Public status and changelog are available

Most important final refinement

Create a single internal document called:

Semester Definition of Done

It should contain the one standard every feature, launch, contract, integration, and claim must meet.

Does it help a real user complete a meaningful job?
Does it fit the unified Semester system?
Is the data persistent, authorized, sourced, and explainable?
Does it work accessibly and on mobile?
Is it secure, privacy-safe, observable, testable, and supportable?
Can it fail safely?
Can it be configured by an institution?
Can it be migrated, audited, exported, retained, and deleted appropriately?
Can the company honestly sell and support it?

If the answer is “no” to any of those questions, the work is not complete yet.

The final difference between a compelling vision and a market-defining company is not another feature. It is the discipline to make every existing feature **real, trustworthy, operational, supported, and provable.**

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1. <https://www.educause.edu/higher-education-community-vendor-assessment-toolkit>
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